Back to Campout for Compassion

Why We’re Here ... A Conversation, Not an Argument

You don’t have to camp out to participate! You can host or join a discussion, invite a speaker, show a video, organize an activity or basic-needs drive, or simply help spread the word. An overnight campout is only one option.

Campout for Compassion 2026 ... Saturday, November 14, 2026

One Night. Many Locations. One Community. Rather than gathering at one central campsite, we’re bringing our community together across many locations for one shared night of awareness, understanding, and compassion.

Chico Campout for Compassion is about changing the narrative ... one conversation at a time. Our goal is to help the public look beyond stereotypes, hear people with firsthand experience, learn facts about homelessness, and examine what is happening in our own community.

Too often, our understanding of homelessness comes from what we see on the street, what we hear in the news, or what others tell us. But how much do we really know about the people experiencing homelessness, the circumstances that brought them there, or the barriers preventing them from finding housing?

See the people. Learn the facts. Start a conversation.

Our approach may appear left-leaning ... but this isn’t about left or right. Facts are facts, and results are results. The best available research, studies, science, and real-world experiences should help us understand the problem rather than determine which side wins an argument.

We all want cleaner, safer parks and waterways, fewer people living on the streets, and neighbors who have a safe place to call home. Those goals do not have to be in conflict.

We are not asking anyone to endorse a particular political position or housing philosophy. We want to distinguish fact from assumption, hear different perspectives, and question harmful stereotypes. We welcome countering evidence and respectful disagreement.

Our recommended educational materials draw primarily on Invisible People’s 2025 *Effective Homelessness Advocacy Messaging Toolkit*, firsthand stories, and independently verified research. The toolkit helps us communicate more effectively; it is not a substitute for Chico-specific statistics. Iain De Jong’s discussion of shared values remains an optional deeper resource, not the central focus of the Campout.

Our educational resource choices reflect a shelter-first and lowest-barrier approach; we do not recommend treatment-first materials. However, people who support other approaches are still welcome to participate and express their views.

An overnight campout is optional ... individuals can participate from home, and organizations can simply encourage their members to join the conversation.

We are not here to tell you what to think. We are not here to tell you how it should be done. We are here to start having conversations ... to learn something, question an assumption, and recognize the humanity of our neighbors.

We do not need to agree on everything to find common ground. Our purpose is dialogue ... nothing more.

Start here: Understanding Homelessness ... Myths, Facts & Realities or explore our video guide.